

The Buccaneer of the Turtle – Part 2

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First English version, poorly translated from the original French text; translation done entirely by chat-gpt.

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Part 2

Chapter 5 : The Shadow of Betrayal

Midnight has just passed on the Caribbean Sea. The gibbous moon casts a ghostly pallor over the two ships sailing in company. La Fortune moves slightly ahead, El Santo Niño obediently following a few cables behind, like a big fish escorted by a remora. On the galleon's deck, the pirates assigned to guard the prize keep watch nonchalantly, now confident. On La Fortune most of the crew sleeps soundly, nestled in hammocks or on the deck, exhausted but happy.

Only a few figures slip through the shadows. The night watch is carried by six men, including Miguel the gunner and Baltazar, a thin helmsman with a scarred face. They whisper to each other from time to time to fend off monotony. Henri Duval, faithful to the promise he made the captain, watches over the quarterdeck himself, sitting near the helmsman, his stocky silhouette draped in a coat to ward off the night chill. He has his back to the ladder leading to the main deck, watching instead the dark horizon. In his right hand he fiddles mechanically with a flintlock pistol – an old habit of his.

He does not hear the shadow—or shadows—slipping silently behind him. Suddenly a flash of steel leaps out of the night: *schlak!* Henri Duval startles and claps a hand to his neck where the point of a dagger has just pricked him. But already another figure lunges and brings a heavy boarding maul down on his skull. Henri collapses heavily without a cry, unconscious or dead. His pistol falls and skids across the planks. The helmsman Baltazar widens his eyes, but before he can make a sound a third shadow levels a weapon at him and hisses, “Don’t move or you’re a dead man.” Frozen, Baltazar nods fearfully, slowly raising his hands.

The attackers now emerge from the darkness: in the moonlight you can make out Miguel, his face twisted in a determined grimace, clutching a bloodied cutlass. At his side stands Achille, the grenadiers’ chief, a hulking fellow with a wicked look, who sheaths his spiked mace. A third accomplice, Rodrigue, keeps his pistol trained on the petrified helmsman. Miguel lets out a little snicker. “Right, lads. We’re there. Baltazar, you’re going to obey nicely now if you don’t want to feed the fish.”

Below, on the main deck, other shapes move. There are seven conspirators in all. Taking advantage of the general sleep, they methodically neutralise the few isolated men on watch. Near the bow, Achille and an accomplice strangle with a rope a half-awake topman who has only time to gurgle before collapsing. Another conspirator knocks out the lookout aloft – poor Yann, who had gone up for his turn on watch. Yann crashes onto the deck with a dull thud, unconscious.

In less than five minutes La Fortune is under the group's control. Miguel comes down from the quarterdeck, stepping over Henri Duval's inert body without a glance. He is joined near the mainmast by the other mutineers. Their faces gleam with sweat and barely contained tension. Achille, eyes shining, asks Miguel in a low voice, "It's done?" – "Yes, Duval's dead; the captain won't be long," spits Miguel with a mix of hatred and euphoria. Achille nods. "Then we go according to the plan."

It appears this plot had perhaps been brewing for some time. Miguel and Achille, in particular, had never been very close to Montreuil or to Duval. The lure of treasure did the rest. They whispered their intentions aboard the galleon during the pillage and rallied a few malcontents and hotheads. Seven men out of forty may seem few, but by night, facing a sleeping crew, it is enough for a lightning coup.

Miguel raises his still-stained cutlass. "No quarter, lads. Montreuil's mine. He'll pay for all those years of lecturing us and taking double shares." There is in his voice an old resentment – perhaps the bitterness of never having been promoted officer, or grudges Montreuil never knew he had incurred. Achille, for his part, seems above all greedy for riches. He states harshly: "We do this quickly and properly. Rodrigue, lock the prisoners' hold and guard the entrances. The rest, with me to the captain's cabin."

They move with muffled steps toward the stern. Only the swell against the hull and the creak of wood accompany their steps. Miguel, for his part, turns away for a moment to climb the ladder to the afterdeck. He glances toward the open sea: El Santo Niño is still moving peacefully. The one-eyed man cannot help a smile: over there, Geoffroy and the others have not yet noticed anything. Miguel then unhooks the shuttered lantern hanging near the helm and covers its opening with his hand so as to let through only a small beam. He then flashes a series of three brief signals toward the galleon. It is a prearranged signal. On El Santo Niño a point of light answers the same way. Ah, the galleon's accomplices are ready, thinks Miguel. Because yes, the treason also extends to the captured vessel: a few pirates left over there have been taken into confidence and will cooperate to get rid of those who remain loyal to Montreuil on the galleon's side, if necessary by force. Thus, the mutiny is complete on both ships.

Miguel goes back down to join Achille in front of Captain Montreuil's cabin door. Two conspirators stand watch in the corridor, weapons in hand. Achille gently turns the handle – the door is not locked. Montreuil, confident on his own ship, was sleeping without mistrust. The grenadiers' chief pushes the door open and slips inside with Miguel into the cramped space.

In the dim light of a lantern burning in a corner, they see Montreuil sprawled on his bunk, lying on his side, an arm hanging off the bed. He is sleeping deeply, exhausted by the battle and perhaps a little by the tafia. On a small table at his side lie his sabre and pistols – out of his immediate reach. Achille and Miguel exchange a knowing look and creep forward. Miguel

draws a slender dagger from his belt, fully intending to sink it into the heart of the man who was their captain. Perhaps he wants to savour for a moment the prospect of this murder: Montreuil led them to glory, but Miguel sees in it only the chance to take possession of the ship and the loot himself.

All at once the plan goes awry. In his sleep, Montreuil must have sensed something – a creak of a plank or a presence – whatever it was, his eye opens. He first sees blurred shapes, but Miguel's silhouette against the shadows is enough for his instincts. With an extraordinary reflex, Montreuil rolls to one side just as the dagger comes down. The blade plants itself in the blanket a few centimetres from his flank. "What... Miguel?!" cries Montreuil, struggling to sit up. The one-eyed man curses and tries to free his weapon from the thick cloth. Achille then appears and strikes Montreuil on the temple with the pommel of his sword before he is fully upright. The captain groans in pain and staggers, but anger and adrenaline keep him partly conscious. He manages to shove Achille away with a forearm, almost throwing himself to the floor to dodge a second blow. His arm stretches toward the small table; with the tips of his fingers he touches the handle of one of his pistols... when Miguel, finally freed from the blanket, drives a knee into his ribs that doubles him over. Montreuil collapses on the cabin floor, gasping, pain radiating through his chest.

"It's over, captain," spits Miguel in an ugly tone as he throws himself on him. Montreuil takes a punch full in the face; he feels the flesh of his cheekbone burst. His vision blurs with red sparks. Achille takes advantage to immobilise his legs. Between them they pin Montreuil on his back. Miguel presses the point of his dagger under Montreuil's throat, just enough to pierce the skin and draw a drop of blood. "Don't move, superstitious dog, or I'll slit your throat on the spot," he hisses. Montreuil, dazed, grasps the situation: a mutiny, his second likely killed, most of his men asleep or already neutralised. A taste of ashes and injustice fills his mouth as much as the metallic flavour of his own blood.

"Why...", he murmurs, staring at Miguel's face contorted with anger. "Why? The gold, you fool!" sneers Achille. "We're not going to share this jackpot among forty ragamuffins." Miguel adds, pressing the blade a bit more under Montreuil's chin: "Your big captain's mouth, we've had enough of it. Mister Saint Barbara who forces us to follow the code, who takes double shares and lectures us. Did you think you were better than us? You're just an obstacle on the road to my fortune, Montreuil." His voice trembles slightly, no doubt with nervous excitement.

Montreuil tries to speak, but Miguel presses his thumb to his bloody mouth. "Hush! I ought to kill you right away... but I want you to see what's happening to you. Tie him up." Achille produces a hemp rope, and in a few seconds Montreuil is bound, wrists tied behind his back and ankles hobbled. They haul him roughly upright onto a chair bolted to the floor. Montreuil is short of breath, a sharp pain in his ribs and his head spinning, but his mind remains clear. A cold rage begins to boil in him, surpassing the surprise and initial fear. He looks intently at Miguel with his piercing grey eyes. "I always treated you loyally, Miguel," he says in a hoarse voice. "You take advantage of the night like a coward..." Miguel slaps him: "Shut up!"

Achille, less emotional, prefers to press on with the plan. "Take him up on deck, let him say goodbye to La Fortune." Montreuil understands the implication: they will probably throw him overboard or force him aboard the galleon before fleeing. In either case, it is the end of his command and probably of his life in the short term.

Dragging him up the narrow ladder, the mutineers haul Montreuil onto the main deck. The captain sees the bodies of two of his men lying in their blood – he vaguely recognises one of the topmen. His heart tightens, but he can only move forward, pushed by Achille. On the quarterdeck Montreuil makes out the stretched shape of Henri Duval. His old friend lies face down on the planks, motionless. A long shiver of pain runs through Montreuil: Is Henri dead? The sight hurts him more than his own injuries. Henri, his brother-in-arms, betrayed at the same time as he.

“Wake those ones,” orders Miguel, pointing to two non-conspirator pirates who were still sleeping rolled in a sail, miraculously ignored in the initial assault. Achille prods them with his foot, weapons in hand, and the two men wake with a start, first incredulous and then appalled at the scene. Miguel tells them, “Your choices: the sea or submission. We’re taking the ship and the treasure. If you shut up and clear out, we spare you. You can go see on the galleon if I’m there.” Panicked and poorly armed, the two companions nod vigorously, raising their hands in surrender. “We... we won’t do anything, Miguel, take what you want...” one stammers. Miguel chuckles: “Good, you’re smart. Go perch over there and don’t move.”

On deck now, there is no immediate opposition left. The mutineers have locked the access to the holds where other pirates are sleeping – they will come up against closed doors if they wake. Everything has happened so quickly and so silently. The unlucky ones who might have seen anything had no time to act.

Montreuil feels the night wind on his nape. La Fortune, his beloved ship, has fallen into the hands of his own men turned renegades. He swallows a mixture of bitterness and shame. Miguel and Achille force him to advance to the starboard rail. There, just a few metres away, tossed by the same swell, El Santo Niño still sails, peaceful. On the galleon’s quarterdeck confusing figures can be seen. Montreuil understands that part of the crew on the galleon is also facing some trouble – perhaps the accomplices Miguel mentioned have taken position there.

Suddenly a flash bursts from the galleon: *bang!* A shot, then indistinct cries. Apparently there is a scuffle on El Santo Niño. Perhaps Geoffroy or other loyalists are resisting. Montreuil harbours a brief hope: if the fight starts over there, it might distract his gaolers for a moment...

“Miguel! They’re brawling on the galleon!” shouts a mutineer posted on the aftercastle. Miguel curses in Spanish, seeing his plan in danger. “No choice, lads, we go right now. Fire at them to keep them away!” he orders. Without waiting, Achille and two others fire muskets toward the galleon, without aiming particularly, but to show they are ready to kill. On El Santo Niño you can see a stir: figures lie down on the deck to avoid the bullets.

Miguel takes advantage of the moment to put the last stage of his plan into action. He leans toward Montreuil, still securely bound. “Captain Adrien Montreuil...” he begins in a falsely ceremonious voice, “By decree of us, members of this crew, you are relieved of your command. Your treason – ha ha, ironic – against the crew earns you death or banishment. For my part, I’d rather send you to the bottom, but Achille thinks we should leave you on your precious galleon, with your dear Spaniards and your loyal wounded, just to see how long you survive. We’ll go for charity.” He punctuates it with a crooked smile. Montreuil straightens despite everything, blood running down his brow, and manages, “You won’t get away with it, Miguel. The Brethren of the Coast will hunt you down for this.” Miguel bursts out laughing:

“The Brethren of the Coast? You really think after this we’re going to show up in Tortuga like nothing happened? No, old boy. With this gold, goodbye to the brotherhood.

We’ll go and retire far from here, where no one will find us. Maybe to Madagascar or Veracruz, who knows. But you will never know, because this is where our paths diverge.”

With a gesture, he signals to Achille and Rodrigue. They grab Montreuil under the armpits. The captain tries to struggle, but his bonds cut into him and they are stronger. They lift him onto the rail. Montreuil sees below the black water, cleft by the galleon’s prow advancing close by. They have calculated their manoeuvre: they are going to throw him overboard so that he lands back on the deck of the enemy galleon, abandoned to whatever is happening there.

“And for your legendary luck, here, take this back!” he adds mockingly, stuffing a small cloth pouch into Montreuil’s pocket. It is... Montreuil’s *gris-gris* amulet! Miguel had picked it up on the deck earlier. Montreuil has no time to react before his two executioners already hurl him into the void.

The world tips over: Montreuil feels himself flying for an instant, head down, then a brutal encounter with wood. He crashes full length onto the deck of El Santo Niño with a sinister crack. A sharp pain shoots through his thigh and shoulder – the three-metre fall has badly shaken him. He rolls onto his side groaning, stunned. By some miracle he has not lost consciousness, but the impact leaves him almost paralysed for a few moments, the breath knocked out of him.

At the same moment he hears La Fortune tacking: the mutineers set the sails and steer away quickly from the galleon. They fire another cannon broadside over the stern of El Santo Niño for good measure, then flee into the night, running with the wind. Montreuil, powerless, watches his beloved ship disappear little by little, its sails blending into the darkness. He has lost everything in a heartbeat – his crew, his ship, his hard-won treasure, and his dearest friend.

The galleon’s deck is chaos. The few pirates who remained loyal to Montreuil – among them Geoffroy, the boatswain, wounded in the arm, and young Yann, who had been brought there unconscious – stand dazed while the conspirators on the galleon flee in a boat to rejoin La Fortune, leaving the ship to its fate. The Spanish prisoners, meanwhile, miss nothing of the agitation. A few Spanish seamen, freed in the confusion by an improbable set of circumstances, pick up abandoned weapons.

Still bound, Montreuil manages with difficulty to sit up. He sees Geoffroy and two more of his men rushing toward him. “Captain! Good God... they threw you from the sky!” Geoffroy quickly cuts his bonds with a knife. Montreuil stands up, staggering, leaning on Yann’s shoulder, who despite a huge bump on his head clings to him to support him. “The dogs...” mutters Montreuil, his voice broken more by emotion than by his aching ribs.

Montreuil takes a deep breath to compose himself. He swallows his grief and rage – he will have time later to succumb to it. For now, he remains captain of what he can salvage. “My friends, the situation is critical. La Fortune has abandoned us. Miguel, Achille... all those renegades have the gold and our provisions.” He looks around: El Santo Niño is almost helpless,

its torn sails hang down, no one holds the helm anymore. The ship has already begun to luff uncontrollably. "If we stay here, we'll end up adrift or recaptured by the Spaniards."

As if to confirm his words, a cry rings out: "¡A ellos!" On the aftercastle a handful of liberated Spanish sailors have just burst forth, armed with sabres and boat hooks, led by the Spanish captain, his arm in a sling but his gaze blazing with vengeance. Taking advantage of the chaos, they have been released by some of their countrymen who were initially tied up. These Spaniards are indeed exhausted, some wounded, but they now outnumber the remaining pirates. There must be about twenty more or less able Spaniards facing seven loyal pirates left.

Montreuil realises a new fight is coming, reversed this time: the former vanquished regain courage and turn their blades against them. Geoffroy and Yann gather around him, the other buccaneers close ranks. "Captain, what do we do?" cries Yann, aghast at this reversal of fortune. Montreuil clenches his teeth, scans the deck and spots near the mast a swivel gun (a small pivoting cannon) loaded, abandoned there during the initial confrontation and not used earlier. "See to trimming the foretopsail sheet, we have to manoeuvre!" orders Montreuil suddenly. Surprised, his companions obey by reflex: manoeuvre? And against whom? But Montreuil, as a strategist, has a crazy plan: to use the ship itself as a weapon.

With a sudden impulse, he rushes to the helm and seizes it firmly, despite the pain in his ribs. He pulls with all his strength to bring the ship around to starboard. El Santo Niño slowly begins to turn. The Spaniards coming down from the aftercastle lose their balance when the deck tilts slightly under the sudden action. Montreuil shouts to Geoffroy, "Are the portside guns loaded?" Geoffroy, understanding at once, yells at two men to go and check. Fortunately, at least two pieces on that side had been loaded earlier. Montreuil straightens the helm at the right angle: El Santo Niño, still docile, now points her port flank... toward La Fortune, which can be glimpsed in the distance, sailing away but still visible.

"Fire on them, light the match!" roars Montreuil. One of his pirates, Dieudonné, sets fire to the cartridge of a 12-pounder. The shot goes off with a crash: the ball whistles through the night toward La Fortune. They cannot see if it hits at that distance, but a few seconds later a brief flash appears on the poop of the far-off schooner. "Hit, I think!" exclaims Yann who is watching. Montreuil hopes at least that it will have given them cause for concern.

But there is no time to press the attack; the Spaniards are now upon them, screaming like devils who have regained their wings. Montreuil draws a pistol left in his belt (miraculously his mutineers had not completely disarmed him) and shoots dead the first soldier who charges toward him on the poop. Geoffroy just parries a pike thrust and drives his cutlass into his assailant's thigh, who howls and falls. Soon there is a confused melee on the ravaged deck of the galleon: pirates and Spaniards, their roles reversed, butcher each other in a fury of despair.

Montreuil, weakened but unleashed by anger and the will to survive, fights like a wounded lion. He has picked up a boarding axe and brings it down on a Spanish sailor who was trying to encircle him. The man collapses, his blood splashing the already dark wood. Yann, the slender topman, miraculously agile, slips behind a burly Spanish gunner and smashes him on the back of the skull with a gunstock, knocking him out. But they are overwhelmed: two pirates fall under enemy blades, among them Dieudonné, who collapses groaning, pierced through and through by a bayonet.

The Spanish captain, brandishing his rapier, swoops on Montreuil who has just tripped over a rope. “¡Pagarás por mis hombres, maldito francés!” he spits. Montreuil parries with the shaft of his axe as best he can. The blade glances off and wounds him on the forearm; he drops his weapon involuntarily under the pain. The enemy captain grabs him by the throat with one hand, ready to deliver a fatal thrust with his raised rapier. Montreuil, driven against the bulwark, meets the Spaniard’s hateful gaze and reads no mercy there: this is the end.

A shot rings out suddenly: the Spanish captain opens wide, surprised eyes, seized by a jolt. A red stain blossoms on his shirt over his heart. His grip loosens and Montreuil, panting, pushes him away. The officer collapses slowly to the deck, dead before he hits it. Behind him stands Yann, pistol smoking in his hand, his face dazed but fierce: it is he who has just shot down the enemy chief to save his captain.

This death surprises the remaining Spaniards. Demoralised and weary, they fall back when one of them shouts that the captain is dead. Taking advantage of their wavering, Montreuil, Geoffroy and the survivors gather their last strength and counterattack. The impact is decisive: the Spaniards drop their weapons one after another and surrender, terrified of being slaughtered without their leader to rally them. Some even flee by jumping overboard into the sea, taking the crazy risk of swimming to some hypothetical shore rather than falling into the hands of enraged pirates.

Everything falls silent again, except for the groans of the wounded and the crackle of a nascent fire quickly put out on a line. Montreuil staggers and has to lean on Geoffroy. The captain is breathing with difficulty, his vision blurs: the backlash of his wounds strikes violently now that the adrenaline is ebbing. “We... we held,” he murmurs, more to himself than to the others. Geoffroy nods, his face grim: of the seven pirates they had left, only four are still standing. Yann unharmed except for his bump, Geoffroy wounded in the arm and flank, Montreuil bruised all over, and another, Alric, limping badly but alive. On the deck lie about a dozen defeated Spaniards. The rest – a handful – kneel, hands on their necks, trembling as they await their fate.

Montreuil totters over to the mast and leans heavily against it. He contemplates with dismay the cramped battlefield that only a few hours before had been a victorious ship under his command. Now El Santo Niño is nothing more than a barely manoeuvrable hulk, crewed by a bloodless few and... no more enemies in sight. But his ship, La Fortune, has disappeared with the traitors and the treasure. Heavy-hearted, Montreuil slides down the mast until he sits on the blood-stained deck. Geoffroy approaches, tying a rag around his own wound. He lays a compassionate hand on his captain’s shoulder. “Captain... what do we do now?” he asks, his voice tinged with both grief and loyalty. Montreuil slowly shakes his head, still too stunned to answer. He turns his face toward the open sea. In the east, a pale halo heralds the coming dawn. A new day rises over the Caribbean Sea, washing with its nascent light the blood and tears of the fateful night. Adrien Montreuil closes his eyes for a moment, murmuring almost inaudibly, “My God... give me strength...” Deep inside, a fierce resolve begins to take shape, fuelled by the pain: he is not finished. As long as he has breath left, he will not surrender.

Chapter 6 : Winds of Vengeance

The rising sun bathes El Santo Niño in an orange glow. Montreuil and his three surviving companions work as best they can to make the galleon seaworthy again. It is a Herculean task given their small number and exhaustion, but urgency drives them: they cannot remain idle, for fear of becoming an easy target for anyone or drifting toward a hostile shore.

First, they tend to the wounded. Yann goes down to the galley to fetch water and rum to clean the wounds. Montreuil, though in pitiful condition, uses the rudiments of medicine he learned long ago alongside the surgeon Desmarais to bandage Alric's leg and roughly sew up Geoffroy's arm with sail thread. They in turn insist that he bind his own broken ribs tightly and cover with clean cloth the deep gash on his forearm. Every movement wrenches a grimace of pain from Montreuil, but he suppresses it stoically. His cold hatred for the traitors numbs his physical aches in part: he focuses his mind on one single objective now, catching up with Miguel and reclaiming what is rightfully his.

Next, they assess the ship's seaworthiness. The galleon has suffered: sails holed, rigging tangled, but the masts stand firm and the hull has no significant leak. Montreuil notes that during the fight La Fortune only fired a warning broadside and not at full power: the galleon remains structurally sound. It is their plank of salvation – ironic fate, this vessel they had captured for its booty now becomes their only means to pursue their enemies.

They are only four to handle such a colossus designed for more than fifty seamen, but Montreuil does not admit defeat. He assigns roles: Geoffroy at the helm, Yann and Alric on deck for sail handling, himself lending support and coordinating. They hoist with difficulty the main foresail and roughly repair the mizzen's brigantine to get a bit of propulsion. El Santo Niño, docile, responds slowly to the efforts of this miniature crew. The wind blows weakly from the south-east that morning, allowing them to set an approximate course north-northwest.

Meanwhile, Montreuil has the remaining Spanish prisoners interrogated. Only five Spanish sailors are still alive under his control, including a helmsman and two able seamen. Montreuil, no longer having numbers on his side, changes his attitude toward them: he offers them their lives if they cooperate in navigating the galleon to the next port. All too happy to escape certain death, these men accept, nodding vigorously. The buccaneer captain personally unties them and directs them to resume their posts as sailors under his supervision.

With these extra hands, sailing El Santo Niño becomes more realistic. They reinforce the sails, clear the deck of battle debris, and throw a few bodies overboard in a final silent farewell. Yann wipes away a tear watching the bodies disappear under the waves. Montreuil lays a hand on his shoulder. "They deserve that we carry on. Courage, lad. We will not fail." The young man nods, his gaze bright with pain and determination mingled.

Hours pass. Under Montreuil's direction, El Santo Niño traces as best it can the route he assumes La Fortune is taking. The schooner, light and fast, has gained ground – but perhaps not as much as Miguel would like, because Montreuil struck her with his cannon just in time. They have no certainty, but Montreuil hopes the impact has damaged her rudder or rigging a bit, slowing her down. In any case, Miguel cannot head straight for Tortuga: he knows the port might not welcome him if it learns of his deed. More likely, the mutineers will set course for a

refuge or hideout beyond the reach of the French or English authorities – perhaps Providence Island, or the Bahama islets, or even attempt to reach the coast of Honduras to disappear there.

Montreuil thinks hard about Miguel's options. He knows the mentality of these men: they will first want to put themselves in safety, then divide the gold. That implies an isolated place out of reach. A memory returns to him: during their return to Tortuga, Achille mentioned a sheltered cove near the island of La Gonâve off Haiti where he had once stopped. La Gonâve is deserted and little frequented, perfect for hiding a ship for a while. And geographically it is on the likely escape route of La Fortune, which headed full northwest during the night.

He shares his intuition with Geoffroy, who approves. "That makes sense. We are farther south; we can try to hug the windward coast of Hispaniola then head up toward La Gonâve. If they are there, we will find them." Montreuil is aware, however, that their galleon, though bigger, is slower. The mutineers will have the leisure to hide or to flee again if they spot them from afar. They would need guile to get close, as they themselves had done with the galleon.

He therefore decides to avoid hoisting any pirate emblem: El Santo Niño will keep the Spanish flag if there is an intact one left. That will allow them to approach without alerting any lookouts. By chance, a spare Spanish flag is found in the ship's store; they laboriously hoist it on the mizzen gaff. Thus, the galleon could pass for a Spanish vessel on business as usual – at least from a distance.

Late in the afternoon, as they skirt the verdant coasts of Hispaniola, Montreuil summons Yann and Geoffroy around a compass and nautical charts found in the cabin. On one of them he points out La Gonâve. "We should be there by dawn tomorrow, if the wind holds," he says. "We'll look for a cove on the island's northern coast; Achille mentioned a mooring called Parrot Cove, I think." The irony of the name brings a smile to Yann, who notes how the notion of luck has shattered for them recently. Montreuil, guessing his thought, says calmly, "I no longer believe in chance or amulets. Our fate is in our hands and our courage. Count only on that."

His companions nod gravely. Montreuil has abandoned his illusion of divine favour or malice. Too many setbacks have shown him destiny's impartial cruelty. Only determined action will count from now on.

In the evening a storm threatens on the horizon, offering a spectacle of distant lightning. El Santo Niño advances cautiously, pushed by a freshening wind. Montreuil organises the watches: with the cooperating Spaniards they can take turns a little. He himself takes the initial night watch. Leaning against the helm he holds firmly, his gaze fixed on the darkness, he feels a ferocious resolve building inside him. Each splash reminds him of La Fortune's drift, each groan of the hull whispers to him the names of the traitors. He will not let Miguel and Achille enjoy their theft. He has sworn it on Henri's body, on his own soul.

In the night, when all is calm, a trembling voice rises behind him. It is Baltazar, the helmsman who had been forced to cooperate with the mutineers on La Fortune. They found him hiding during the inspection afterwards. He submitted immediately and Montreuil, out of pragmatism, did not execute him on the spot although he might have helped Miguel out of fear. The man has just brought diluted coffee to the captain. "Captain Montreuil... I... I'm sorry," he whispers shamefully. "I couldn't do anything. They would have killed

me..." Montreuil listens without replying at first, sipping the bitter drink that scrapes his throat. Then, without turning his head, he says in a neutral tone, "Baltazar, I understand fear. But know that fear doesn't excuse everything. You let my friend get his throat cut behind you." The sailor breaks into silent tears, almost kneeling. "Forgive me, forgive me..." Montreuil closes his eyes for a moment: he feels contempt but also a certain pity. "Get up. I won't kill you. Your fate is tied to ours now. If we fail, you will probably die. If we succeed... then perhaps you will have redeemed your cowardice by helping us. Go." Baltazar bows and walks away, surprised to be alive. Montreuil sighs. The cycle of betrayal has done its work; he doesn't want to feed it further by punishing this coward now. His vengeance is reserved for the ringleaders, not for frightened followers.

At dawn, as planned, the island of La Gonâve appears in the mist. It is a mountainous, arid mass, surrounded by pale beaches. Montreuil has some canvas lowered to advance without drawing attention. The nascent day gives them enough light to scrutinise the coves. Geoffroy is on lookout with Montreuil's telescope recovered from the galleon.

After two hours of slow exploration along La Gonâve's north coast, Yann, who has climbed the foremast for agility, waves an arm excitedly. "Sail in sight in the eastern cove!" Montreuil rushes to the bow for a better view. He indeed makes out the top of a mast sticking out of a cove surrounded by low hills. One mast, then a second smaller one. No doubt: it is a schooner or a brig, probably La Fortune. They have hidden in this deserted cove, just as Montreuil had guessed.

His heart beats faster: he has them. But the approach remains delicate. Montreuil does not rush headlong. He knows that if he shows himself in broad daylight, the mutineers will have time to flee or prepare. He therefore chooses patience: he has the sails covered and orders that they anchor under the shelter of a rocky point, out of sight of the cove. They will spend the day lying low, roughly repairing the rigging and reloading the guns while observing the enemy anchorage from afar.

At sunset, as the horizon blazes, Montreuil gathers his companions on the quarterdeck. "Listen to me. La Fortune is over there, and we have only one chance. At night we will approach without lanterns, all sails furled, letting wind and current carry us. We will muffle the noise of the chains with rags, we will keep our orders in whispers. When we are alongside, our guns will speak for us: one broadside to break their masts and immobilise them. Then we will board. Surprise will be our strength." His men nod gravely: this buccaneer tactic, made of guile as much as brutality, suits them.

Night falls, and a thin moon struggles to pierce the clouds. El Santo Niño gently raises anchor and slips out of her hiding place. All lanterns are hooded, the halyards wrapped in cloth so they won't squeak. Montreuil holds the helm himself, guided by the dark outline of the hills. Of La Fortune you can make out only two black masts standing out against the starry sky and a few flickering embers: the mutineers, convinced they are alone, are scarcely keeping watch.

At a few cables' distance, Montreuil has four guns loaded with grapeshot and aimed low. He lets the galleon drift until its port flank faces the sleeping schooner. In a whisper he murmurs: "Fire." The night suddenly blazes: four lightning explosions tear the silence, illuminating the cove for a moment as if in broad daylight. The grapeshot and close-range balls rip open La Fortune, tear away her foremast and smash her bulwarks. Splinters and cries spring from

the darkness. The mutineers, surprised in their sleep or taken off guard, run in all directions without understanding where the thunder is coming from.

Without waiting, Montreuil roars, this time at the top of his voice: "Board them! For Henri, for La Fortune!" His cry mingles with the echo of the detonations. A ready skiff is immediately lowered, and Montreuil, Yann, Geoffroy and Alric take their places in it. They row at full speed toward the dismayed deck, taking advantage of the confusion. On the schooner Achille yells orders at random, his leg smashed by the fall of the mast, while water rushes through the gaping hole. Miguel, woken with a start, still dazed by the shock, bleeds from his forehead where a splinter of wood has hit him. He understands too late: it is Montreuil, returned like a vengeful spectre with the galleon they thought they had abandoned.

Barely has the skiff bumped against the side than the pirates scramble onto the shadowed deck. There is almost no resistance: most of the mutineers, injured or panic-stricken, throw themselves into the water or freeze. Only Achille, trapped near the helm, sabre in hand despite his smashed leg, still growls. Miguel, for his part, backs toward the stern, trying to reach a boat in the darkness.

Montreuil scales the bulwark and lands on his deck, flooded with water and debris. His gaze rests for a moment on the damage – his beloved ship is dying, it seems, slowly disembowelled. But no pity: he rushes at Achille. The latter attempts a thrust despite his condition; Montreuil parries with the shaft and counters with a straight punch to the jaw. Achille collapses, knocked out, his sabre falling with a dull thud.

"Miguel!" bellows Montreuil, searching for the one-eyed man's shadow. There he is: Miguel has already set one foot in a boat moored at the stern and is about to jump. Mad with rage, Montreuil leaps like a tiger despite the pain in his ribs. He grabs a pistol fallen in a rack along the way and fires at Miguel. The ball whistles past his shoulder – a near miss. Miguel retaliates by drawing his two pistols and fires almost at point-blank range. Montreuil feels a heat tear through his left flank. He staggers, but holds on, driven by vengeance: the ball has passed right through his flesh, touching no bone or organ, but blood gushes copiously.

Before Miguel has time to reload or flee, Montreuil, crazy with pain and hatred, throws himself on him. The two men tumble into the boat, grappling hand to hand. Miguel draws a knife and tries to plunge it into the back of Montreuil's neck. Montreuil blocks the wrist with one hand and with the other gropes for his second pistol and finds... the *gris-gris* Miguel had given back when he threw him off the ship. In a strange reflex, Montreuil stuffs the pouch into Miguel's mouth, roaring, "Here, swallow your damned luck!" Surprised, Miguel relaxes his hand, the knife falls into the water. Montreuil uses the opportunity to deliver a headbutt that crushes Miguel's nose. The latter screams and teeters; his body tips overboard from the boat. There he is in the water, struggling among the debris.

Montreuil straightens up in the skiff, panting, and takes aim at the one-eyed man with his second pistol. Miguel lifts his head out of the water, spitting and pleading: "Mercy, captain... mercy!" Montreuil, gasping, sees in a flash Henri's murdered face, his sacrificed men. In an icy voice he says, "May God forgive you; I won't." And he pulls the trigger. The ball hits Miguel square in the chest. The traitor opens his mouth without a sound, then his body slowly sinks into the turquoise-blue water of the cove, disappearing in a diffused red cloud.

It's over. Montreuil remains motionless for a moment, his hand trembling, then lets his weapon fall. On *La Fortune*, Yann and Geoffroy have subdued the last mutineers – Achille, unconscious, bound, Rodrigue dead from a cannon splinter, and two others drowned or captured.

But victory has an ashen taste. *La Fortune* is sinking little by little: water floods her holds. Montreuil staggers back onto the deck. He caresses with his eyes the wood of his dear schooner, burned and holed. He whispers almost: "Thank you... you carried us so far." Then, gathering what can be saved (a few bags of gold left on the deck, miraculously intact, and Achille as a prisoner), they abandon the ship. From *La Fortune* they also take her pierced red flag – as a souvenir or a standard of honour.

The return to the galleon is done in silence, each measuring the price of this vengeance. On the beach the buccaneers find that a few chests of gold have been hidden by the mutineers in the sand: they recover them. In the end, Montreuil recovers almost all of the treasure, intact. But at what cost... From the galleon's quarterdeck, Montreuil watches *La Fortune* sink in the cove, soon leaving only a mast to stick out at low tide. He weeps in silence, tears that only the sea wind receives, for his lost ship, for his fallen friends.

Chapter 7 : The Dawn of Redemption

A few days later, *El Santo Niño* – renamed *La Ressource* by Montreuil to mark her new destiny – drops anchor in the roadstead of Tortuga. The news of his triumphant return has spread like wildfire on the buccaneers' island: Montreuil and a handful of his men have captured a fabulous treasure and put down a mutiny.

On the quay a crowd has gathered to watch the unloading of chests of silver and gold escorted by armed pirates. The curious whisper, envious or admiring, and the Brotherhood itself – the captains of Tortuga – comes to congratulate Montreuil, not without making sure the share-out follows the rules.

He also hastens to keep his word to the cooperating Spaniards. Before docking, Montreuil had five Spanish sailors taken back to the nearest Cuban coast with a small stock of provisions – a rare act of clemency. This gesture of pity, born of his disgust at so much carnage, marks a turning point in him. Yesterday a fierce enemy, today he has spared men who helped him. They thanked him with emotion before disappearing into the mangrove. Montreuil will probably never know what became of them, but he felt as he let them go free that he was breaking the cycle of vengeance at his own level.

In Tortuga the atmosphere is one of celebration. Montreuil is hailed as a hero – the buccaneer who survived everything, taking back his due by steel and blood. In the grand tavern of the Whistling Pig a banquet is improvised. Overflowing tankards circulate, voices strike up songs in praise of the buccaneers. Montreuil sits at the centre, a huge tankard of mead before him, but he remains relatively sober and thoughtful. To his right Yann beams like a proud son beside a father. To his left Geoffroy, arm in a sling, tells for the tenth time how Montreuil sank *La Fortune* with a single broadside, embellishing the legend a little more each time.

But Montreuil, for his part, remains modestly silent. He knows what glory has cost him, and what gold will never replace. In his heart he measures the irony of fate: he is rich now, immensely, but his heart is heavy.

Late in the night, as the party dissipates, Montreuil slips out of the tavern. The bright moon lights his figure strolling toward the shore. His gait is slow, cautious – his broken ribs and bandaged wounds still make him suffer. He will probably bear a deep scar on his flank and forearm, stigmata of this odyssey.

He stops on the sand, facing the silver waves. In his hand he holds the medal of Saint Barbara, his old talisman. He takes it off his neck and looks at it for a long time. This object that symbolised so much for him – faith, protection – did not prevent the tragedy. Montreuil squeezes the medal then suddenly throws it with all his strength into the sea. The small silver glint disappears with a discreet *plop*.

He smiles then, a sad but liberated smile. He no longer needs signs or *gris-gris*. He is master of his life, as much as a man can be in the uncertainty of the seas. He knows now that honour and loyalty are fragile, that covetousness can tear apart the strongest bonds, but also that a man can choose to break the chain of hatred.

Montreuil has killed for vengeance, but by sparing others he has found a semblance of peace within himself. Henri's face haunts his thoughts less – he has avenged him. He will mourn, but without shame, for he has kept his promise.

At the end of the beach a silhouette approaches: it is Isabelle, the innkeeper, coming to make sure the hero of the evening lacks for nothing. She comes up softly and hands him a cup of wine. "You'll need this to sleep tonight, Captain," she says with unfeigned solicitude. Montreuil accepts and takes a sip, then he sighs: "Do you ever sleep peacefully, Isabelle? After all you hear and see here..." The matron shrugs. "We make do with our demons, Adrien. Some days, they are quiet."

The captain nods slowly. Yes, he will live with his demons. But he feels a glimmer of hope rising within him: redemption is possible. Tomorrow he will share his treasure fairly, he will compensate the wounded and the widows of the dead. He will strive to be more than the greedy pirate Miguel saw. He vaguely aspires to something better – perhaps to return to France one day, to start a family or to serve a cause more just than mere plunder.

In the distance the night horizon merges with the sea. Montreuil walks into the foam up to his knees, as if to purify himself. Isabelle watches him in silence, then turns back discreetly, understanding that he has a rendezvous with himself.

Montreuil closes his eyes, letting the tepid waves lick his wounds and rinse his skin covered with the traces of battle. The waves murmur an ancient song around him. In that noise he thinks he hears the voice of the sea – that cruel and sublime lover – partly forgiving him, or at least welcoming him as one of its own who has paid the price.

When at last he opens his eyes, a new day begins to dawn in the east, behind the hills of Tortuga. A ray of rosy light pierces the dark sky, announcing the dawn. Adrien Montreuil walks a few steps out of the water, then stops to contemplate this eternal spectacle that moves him every time. His battered heart still beats.

He picks up a small piece of driftwood from the sand and squeezes it in his palm – a simple souvenir of the sea, without superstition, just a tangible link. Then, turning toward the rising sun, he breathes deeply the air laden with salt and promises.

The pirate has closed his odyssey of vengeance. Now perhaps he will begin a new chapter, guided by hard-won experience. The code of honour he cherishes, he will carry it higher, aware of its price. In Tortuga, a legend has been born of these events, but he knows the naked truth behind it: fraternity and loyalty are the only treasures worth protecting.

Adrien Montreuil, charismatic buccaneer captain and until then superstitious, lifts his face to the sun's caress. A relative peace settles on his features. He murmurs a few words that only the wind catches: "To you, lost brothers... I hope you rest on better shores." Then he straightens up and, with a confident step, walks back toward the port where his companions await him.

The outrages of the day before are behind him. Ahead of him stretches the immense ocean, indifferent and magnificent, where each new course can be a renewal. Montreuil will venture into it again, no doubt, but with a different eye. For at the end of the night of vengeance he has found the dawn of his redemption.

— Fin —